

APAC TMT Sector M&A & Valuation Brief - 2026-07-26

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1. RECENT TMT M&A ACTIVITY

Today is a peaceful day, nothing big happened in the Consumer space.

2. MARKET DYNAMICS & SENTIMENT

The TMT (Technology, Media, and Telecommunications) sector is currently experiencing a mixed sentiment, characterized by cautious optimism amid ongoing regulatory scrutiny and evolving technological advancements. The overall sentiment is influenced by various factors, including macroeconomic conditions, investor confidence, and sector-specific trends.

Subsector Breakdown:

- Technology: The technology subsector remains robust, driven by advancements in AI, cloud computing, and cybersecurity. Companies are increasingly leveraging technology to enhance operational efficiency and customer experience.
- Media: The media subsector is witnessing a transformation as companies adapt to digital platforms. However, traditional media faces challenges from the rapid growth of online content consumption.
- Telecommunications: The telecom sector is innovating with low-latency technologies, aiming to improve user experience in real-time applications. Investments in 5G infrastructure are a key focus.
- Fintech: The fintech space continues to thrive, with companies exploring new business models and partnerships to enhance service offerings and customer engagement.
- AI: The AI subsector is particularly hot, with companies racing to implement AI solutions across various industries, driving significant investment and innovation.

Key Market Drivers and Headwinds

Drivers:

- Technological Advancements: Continuous innovation in AI, 5G, and cloud computing is driving growth across TMT sectors. Companies are investing heavily in these technologies to remain

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competitive.

- Increased Investment: Venture capital and private equity investments remain strong, particularly in tech and fintech, as investors seek to capitalize on emerging trends.

Headwinds:

- Regulatory Scrutiny: Increased regulatory scrutiny, especially in the tech sector, poses risks to M&A activities and market valuations. Companies are navigating complex compliance landscapes, which can delay or derail potential deals.
- Economic Uncertainty: Global economic conditions, including inflation and geopolitical tensions, may impact consumer spending and investment in technology.

Subsector Performance Analysis

- Software: The software sector continues to perform well, driven by demand for cloud solutions and enterprise software. Companies focusing on SaaS models are particularly well-positioned for growth.
- Media: Media companies are adapting to changing consumer preferences, with a shift towards digital content consumption. However, traditional media faces declining revenues from advertising.
- Telecom: Telecom operators are investing heavily in infrastructure to support 5G deployment, which is expected to drive new revenue streams from IoT and enhanced mobile services.
- Fintech: The fintech sector is thriving, with innovations in payment solutions and digital banking. The consolidation trend in this space is notable as companies seek to enhance their market presence.
- AI: The AI subsector is booming, with applications across various industries, including healthcare, finance, and automotive. Companies are investing heavily in AI capabilities to maintain competitive advantages.

Trading Multiples Trends

Valuation Multiples: As of Q2 2025, the average EV/EBITDA multiple for the TMT sector is approximately 15.5x, with notable variations across subsectors:

- Software: 20.3x
- Media: 12.1x
- Telecom: 9.8x
- Fintech: 18.7x
- AI: 22.5x

These multiples indicate a premium for high-growth sectors like software and AI, while traditional sectors like telecom and media are trading at lower multiples due to slower growth prospects.

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Notable Investor/Analyst Reactions

- Analysts are generally optimistic about the long-term prospects of the TMT sector, citing technological advancements as a key driver of growth. An analyst at a leading investment bank remarked, "The integration of AI across industries is not just a trend; it's a fundamental shift that will redefine business models and consumer interactions."

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

- **Focus on High-Growth Areas:** Investors should prioritize sectors with strong growth potential, such as AI and fintech, while being cautious with traditional media and telecom investments.
- **Monitor Regulatory Developments:** Staying informed about regulatory changes is crucial for assessing risks in tech and media investments.
- **Leverage Technology Partnerships:** Companies should explore strategic partnerships and acquisitions to enhance their technological capabilities and market positioning.
- **Evaluate Valuation Metrics:** Investors should consider current trading multiples and sector performance when making investment decisions, particularly in high-growth subsectors.

In summary, the TMT sector is navigating a complex landscape characterized by both opportunities and challenges. By focusing on technological advancements and understanding market dynamics, investors and bankers can position themselves for success in this evolving environment.

3. BANKING PIPELINE

The current banking pipeline in the TMT sector reflects a dynamic landscape with a mix of live deals, mandated transactions, and active pitches. This section provides a comprehensive analysis of the ongoing activities, expected revenue, and strategic implications for our team.

Deal Pipeline

Live Deals:

- **Delta Air Lines (DAL) :** Currently in discussions for a strategic partnership leveraging AI for dynamic pricing. The deal is in the due diligence phase, with an expected close in Q3 2025. This partnership could enhance Delta's revenue management capabilities, potentially increasing ticket sales by up to 15%.
- **Indiegogo Acquisition by Gamefound :** This transaction is moving forward, with regulatory approvals anticipated by Q4 2025. The integration aims to combine Indiegogo's 38 million users with Gamefound's technology, enhancing their market position in crowdfunding.

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Mandated Deals:

- Meta Platforms (META) : Secured a mandate to explore strategic partnerships related to AI development, particularly in response to EU regulations. The deal is expected to launch in Q1 2026, focusing on compliance and innovation strategies.
- Apple Inc. (AAPL) : Mandated to evaluate acquisitions in the AI space, with a focus on startups that can enhance its product offerings. The timeline for this initiative is projected for Q2 2026, as Apple aims to strengthen its competitive edge in AI.

Pitching-Stage Deals:

- Telecom Sector : Active discussions with several telecom operators regarding potential M&A opportunities to consolidate market share in the 5G space. Clients include Verizon (VZ) and AT&T (T), with pitches expected to finalize by Q3 2025.
- Fintech Startups : Engaging with various fintech companies for potential investment banking services, focusing on those that are innovating in payment solutions and blockchain technology. Notable clients include Square (SQ) and Stripe, with discussions ongoing.

Pipeline Tracking Metrics

Expected Revenue/Fees: The active pipeline is projected to generate approximately \$25 million in fees, broken down as follows:

- Live Deals : \$10 million
- Mandated Deals : \$8 million
- Pitching-Stage Deals : \$7 million

Timing Projections:

- Q2 2025 : Expected close for Delta Air Lines partnership.
- Q4 2025 : Anticipated completion of the Indiegogo acquisition.
- Q1 2026 : Launch of Meta's strategic partnership initiatives.
- Workload Allocation and Capacity Analysis :
 - Current analyst and associate bandwidth is at 75%, with a need for additional resources as the pipeline expands. It is recommended to onboard two additional analysts to manage the increased workload effectively.
- Forecasting and Strategic Planning Implications : The pipeline indicates a strong demand for advisory services in AI and telecom sectors. Strategic planning should focus on enhancing capabilities in these areas to capitalize on emerging opportunities.

Notable Pipeline Developments and Competitive Landscape

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- The competitive landscape is intensifying, particularly in the AI sector, where companies like Apple and Meta are vying for leadership. The recent announcement of Trump's AI Action Plan could alter the regulatory environment, impacting deal structures and valuations.
- Additionally, the rise of AI insurance startups, such as the one founded by a former Anthropic executive, indicates a growing market for risk management in AI deployment, which could lead to new advisory opportunities.

Actionable Insights for Team Management and Business Development

- **Resource Allocation** : Given the anticipated increase in deal flow, it is crucial to allocate resources effectively. Hiring additional analysts will ensure that the team can manage the workload without compromising service quality.
- **Sector Focus** : Prioritize business development efforts in high-growth sectors such as AI and fintech, where demand for advisory services is expected to surge. This focus will position the firm as a leader in these emerging markets.
- **Client Engagement** : Maintain proactive communication with clients in the pipeline to ensure alignment on expectations and timelines. Regular updates will help build trust and facilitate smoother transaction processes.

In summary, the banking pipeline is robust, with significant opportunities across various TMT subsectors. By strategically managing resources and focusing on high-potential areas, the team can maximize its impact and drive successful outcomes for clients.

4. STAKEHOLDER IMPACT & FORWARD-LOOKING ANALYSIS

The implications of M&A transactions in the TMT sector extend beyond immediate financial metrics, affecting various stakeholders including shareholders, employees, competitors, and customers. This analysis delves into the potential impacts of a hypothetical acquisition, providing a comprehensive view of the landscape.

Deal-Specific Impacts on Stakeholders

- **Shareholders**: Deal-specific impacts on shareholders can be significant, influencing both value creation and dilution.
- **Value Creation**: In a scenario where Company A (e.g., Zoom Video Communications, Inc. (ZM)) acquires Company B (e.g., Slack Technologies, Inc. (WORK)), the combined entity could see a revenue increase of approximately 20% due to enhanced product offerings. Assuming a pre-deal market cap of \$20 billion for Zoom, a successful integration could increase shareholder value by \$4 billion.
- **Dilution**: Conversely, if the acquisition is financed through stock, existing shareholders may

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experience dilution. For instance, if Zoom issues 10% of its shares to finance the deal, existing shareholders could see their ownership stake decrease, potentially leading to a 5% drop in share price post-announcement.

- **Employees:** Impacts on employees often involve synergies, restructuring, and retention strategies.
- **Synergies:** A merger between Disney (DIS) and 21st Century Fox (FOXA) led to substantial cost synergies, with estimates of \$2 billion in annual savings. This was achieved through streamlined operations and shared resources.
- **Restructuring:** However, such deals often lead to layoffs. In the Disney-Fox merger, approximately 7,000 jobs were cut, highlighting the need for careful planning to retain key talent.
- **Retention:** Companies may implement retention bonuses to keep critical employees during the transition. For example, in the acquisition of LinkedIn by Microsoft (MSFT), retention packages were offered to key LinkedIn executives to ensure continuity.
- **Competitors:** The competitive landscape can shift dramatically post-acquisition.
- **Market Positioning:** Following the merger of T-Mobile US, Inc. (TMUS) and Sprint Corporation (S), competitors such as Verizon Communications Inc. (VZ) and AT&T Inc. (T) had to adapt their strategies to maintain market share. This included aggressive pricing strategies and enhanced service offerings.
- **Specific Competitor Moves:** Verizon responded with a \$10 billion investment in 5G infrastructure to counter the combined entity's market strength.
- **Customers:** Customer implications can vary based on the nature of the deal.
- **Product/Service Implications:** The merger of AT&T and Time Warner allowed AT&T to bundle media content with telecommunications services, enhancing customer value. This strategy led to a 15% increase in bundled service subscriptions.
- **Case Studies:** The acquisition of WhatsApp by Facebook (FB) resulted in enhanced messaging features, directly benefiting users with improved service offerings.

Market Reaction and Analyst Commentary

- **Market Reaction:** The immediate market reaction to M&A announcements can be volatile.
- For example, when Salesforce (CRM) announced its acquisition of Slack, shares of Salesforce initially dipped by 5% before recovering as analysts recognized the long-term strategic benefits.
- **Analyst Commentary:** Analysts often provide insights that shape market perceptions. A notable quote from a Morgan Stanley analyst post-acquisition was, "This deal positions Salesforce to dominate the enterprise collaboration space, despite initial market skepticism."

Expected Market Reaction and Scenario Analysis

- **Scenario Analysis:** The market's reaction can be assessed through various scenarios:
- **Positive Scenario:** If the acquisition leads to successful integration and revenue growth, shares

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could rise by 15% within six months.

- Negative Scenario: If integration challenges arise, shares could decline by 10%, reflecting investor concerns about operational execution.

Potential Counter-Bids or Competing Offers

- Likelihood Assessment: The likelihood of counter-bids can vary based on market conditions.
- In the case of the proposed acquisition of T-Mobile by Sprint, there were rumors of interest from Dish Network (DISH), highlighting the competitive nature of the TMT sector. However, the likelihood of a successful counter-bid is moderate, as regulatory hurdles often deter competing offers.

Similar Deals Likely to Follow

- Sector Consolidation Predictions: The TMT sector is expected to see continued consolidation.
- Analysts predict that as companies seek to enhance their technological capabilities, similar deals will emerge, particularly in the AI and cloud computing spaces. Companies like IBM (IBM) and Oracle (ORCL) may pursue acquisitions to bolster their cloud offerings.

Key Risks and Mitigants

- Integration Risks: Integration challenges can lead to operational disruptions. Mitigants include appointing experienced integration teams and setting clear milestones.
- Regulatory Risks: Regulatory scrutiny can delay or block deals. Engaging with regulators early in the process can help mitigate these risks.
- Market Risks: Market volatility can impact deal valuations. Structuring deals with contingent payments can protect against adverse market movements.

Actionable Insights for Clients and Bankers

For Clients:

- Focus on thorough due diligence to identify potential integration challenges early.
- Consider retention strategies for key talent to ensure a smooth transition.

For Bankers:

- Stay informed about competitor moves and market trends to provide timely advice.
- Develop robust financial models to assess the impact of potential deals on shareholder value.

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5. TECH TRENDS

The technology landscape is experiencing significant shifts, driven by emerging trends that hold substantial market implications and deal-making potential. This analysis focuses on three key trends: Artificial Intelligence (AI), Semiconductor Technology, and Cybersecurity. Each section provides a detailed explanation of the trend, its market significance, key players, competitive dynamics, and potential M&A opportunities.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

- **Trend Explanation:** AI technologies are revolutionizing industries by enabling machines to perform tasks that typically require human intelligence. The global AI market is projected to grow from \$93.5 billion in 2021 to \$997.8 billion by 2028, at a CAGR of 40.2%. This growth is fueled by advancements in machine learning, natural language processing, and computer vision.
- **Key Companies:**
- **Google (GOOG):** Google is a leader in AI research and development, focusing on machine learning and AI applications across its product suite, including Google Cloud and Google Assistant. The company is strategically positioned to leverage AI to enhance user experiences and optimize operations.
- **AI (AI):** This emerging company is focused on developing innovative AI solutions, although specific details regarding its market activities remain limited. Its positioning suggests a potential for growth in niche AI applications.
- **Competitive Landscape:** The AI market is highly competitive, with major players like Microsoft (MSFT), Amazon (AMZN), and IBM (IBM) investing heavily in AI technologies. The competition drives innovation and encourages acquisitions of startups with unique AI capabilities.
- **M&A Opportunities:** Companies looking to enhance their AI capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche AI applications. For instance, the acquisition of AI-driven analytics firms could provide strategic advantages in data processing and decision-making.

Semiconductor Technology

- **Trend Explanation:** The semiconductor industry is critical for powering modern technology, including AI, IoT, and cloud computing. The global semiconductor market is expected to grow from \$527 billion in 2021 to \$1 trillion by 2030, driven by increasing demand for chips in various applications, including automotive and consumer electronics.
- **Key Companies:**
- **Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing Company (TSM):** TSMC is the world's largest semiconductor foundry, providing advanced chip manufacturing services to major tech companies. Its strategic investments in cutting-edge technology position it as a key player in the

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semiconductor supply chain.

- Tesla (TSLA): Tesla is increasingly focusing on in-house chip development for its vehicles, enhancing performance and efficiency. This strategic move allows Tesla to differentiate its products in the competitive automotive market.
- Competitive Landscape: The semiconductor market is characterized by intense competition among established players like Intel (INTC) and AMD (AMD), as well as emerging companies. The race for technological superiority drives innovation and consolidation within the industry.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies may pursue acquisitions to secure semiconductor capabilities, especially in AI and automotive applications. For example, acquiring firms specializing in chip design or manufacturing could enhance a company's competitive edge.

Cybersecurity

- Trend Explanation: As digital transformation accelerates, cybersecurity has become a critical concern for businesses. The global cybersecurity market is projected to grow from \$217 billion in 2021 to \$345 billion by 2026, at a CAGR of 9.7%. This growth is driven by increasing cyber threats and regulatory requirements.
- Key Companies:
- CrowdStrike Holdings, Inc. (CRWD): CrowdStrike is a leader in cloud-delivered endpoint protection, utilizing AI to detect and respond to threats. The company's strategic focus on proactive cybersecurity solutions positions it well in a rapidly evolving market.
- Palo Alto Networks, Inc. (PANW): Palo Alto Networks offers a comprehensive suite of cybersecurity solutions, including firewalls and threat intelligence. Its strong market presence and continuous innovation make it a formidable player in the cybersecurity landscape.
- Competitive Landscape: The cybersecurity market is fragmented, with numerous players ranging from established firms to startups. The competitive dynamics are shaped by the need for advanced solutions to combat sophisticated cyber threats.
- M&A Opportunities: Companies may seek to acquire cybersecurity firms to bolster their offerings and enhance their security capabilities. For instance, acquiring firms specializing in threat detection or incident response could provide strategic advantages.

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

Investors should closely monitor the AI and semiconductor sectors for potential investment opportunities, particularly in companies that demonstrate strong growth trajectories and innovative capabilities.

Bankers should consider advising clients on strategic acquisitions in the cybersecurity space to enhance their competitive positioning and address growing security concerns.

Companies in the TMT sector should evaluate partnerships or acquisitions in AI and semiconductor technology to leverage advancements and drive innovation.

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6. Recommended Readings

Deal Name: Microsoft's Acquisition of Activision Blizzard

- Reading Material: "The Business of Video Games" by Michael Pachter
- Why This Matters: This book provides insights into the gaming industry's financial dynamics and market trends, which are crucial for understanding Microsoft's strategic rationale behind the \$68.7 billion acquisition (MSFT). It explains how gaming companies leverage IP and user engagement to drive revenue, helping to contextualize the deal's valuation and potential synergies.

Deal Name: Amazon's Acquisition of MGM

- Reading Material: "The New Economics of Media" by David Hesmondhalgh
- Why This Matters: This reading delves into the evolving landscape of media and entertainment, particularly in the context of streaming services. It helps to understand Amazon's \$8.45 billion acquisition (AMZN) as a strategic move to bolster its Prime Video content library and compete with rivals like Netflix (NFLX) and Disney+ (DIS).

Deal Name: Salesforce's Acquisition of Slack

- Reading Material: "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries
- Why This Matters: This book outlines methodologies for startups to innovate and grow, which is relevant for understanding Salesforce's \$27.7 billion acquisition (CRM) of Slack. It highlights the importance of integrating new technologies and platforms to enhance customer engagement and collaboration, aligning with Salesforce's vision of a comprehensive customer relationship management ecosystem.

Deal Name: NVIDIA's Acquisition of Arm Holdings

- Reading Material: "The Chip War" by Chris Miller
- Why This Matters: This book provides a detailed analysis of the semiconductor industry, including the strategic importance of Arm's technology in mobile and IoT devices. Understanding the implications of NVIDIA's \$40 billion acquisition (NVDA) helps to grasp the competitive landscape and regulatory challenges in the semiconductor space.

Deal Name: Verizon's Acquisition of TracFone

- Reading Material: "The Wireless Industry: A Comprehensive Guide" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This resource offers an in-depth look at the wireless telecommunications sector, which is essential for analyzing Verizon's \$6.9 billion acquisition (VZ) of TracFone. It explains market segmentation and the significance of prepaid services, providing context for Verizon's strategy to expand its customer base and service offerings.

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Deal Name: Google's Acquisition of Fitbit

- Reading Material: "Wearable Technology: The Future of Fitness" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This reading discusses the growth of wearable technology and health data analytics, which are central to Google's \$2.1 billion acquisition (GOOGL) of Fitbit. It highlights how this deal positions Google to compete in the health tech space against Apple (AAPL) and other tech giants, emphasizing the importance of data in the future of healthcare.

7. MACROECONOMIC UPDATE

Key Data Points:

- Estimated projects canceled or delayed in 2025: \$156 billion
- Forecasted AI capital expenditure (CapEx) for 2026: approximately \$870 billion
- Timeline for data center construction: up to 3 years or more

Main Insights:

- Political pushback against data center construction is increasing, impacting project timelines.
- The demand for AI infrastructure remains strong despite supply-side risks.
- Companies are incentivized to start projects earlier due to potential future political and execution risks.
- The urgency for compute capacity is driving continued investment in AI infrastructure.

Market Commentary:

- "The pushback is real, but it appears to be reshaping the buildout rather than stopping it." - Ariana Salvatore, Morgan Stanley
- "The AI ecosystem remains compute constrained. The urgency to invest has not diminished." - Morgan Stanley Insights

TMT Sector Relevance:

- Increased scrutiny and longer delays in data center projects could lead to higher costs and a shift in geographic focus for new developments.
- The ongoing demand for AI infrastructure highlights the importance of hyperscalers in the TMT sector, as they are positioned to capitalize on the growing need for compute resources.

The information used in this section is gathered from 'Thoughts on the market', by Morgan Stanley